



Aurora borealis

The spectacular natural light show known as the aurora borealis, or northern lights, is a dazzling spectacle of ribbons and sheets of green, yellow, and pink light.

The cause of the aurora is a stream of charged particles ejected from the surface of the sun, known as the solar wind. These particles are guided toward the poles by Earth's magnetic field. When they hit oxygen and nitrogen molecules in the atmosphere, electrons in the molecules emit colored light. The northern lights—and aurora australis, or southern lights, around the South Pole—occur whenever the solar wind blows, typically about two hundred nights a year.